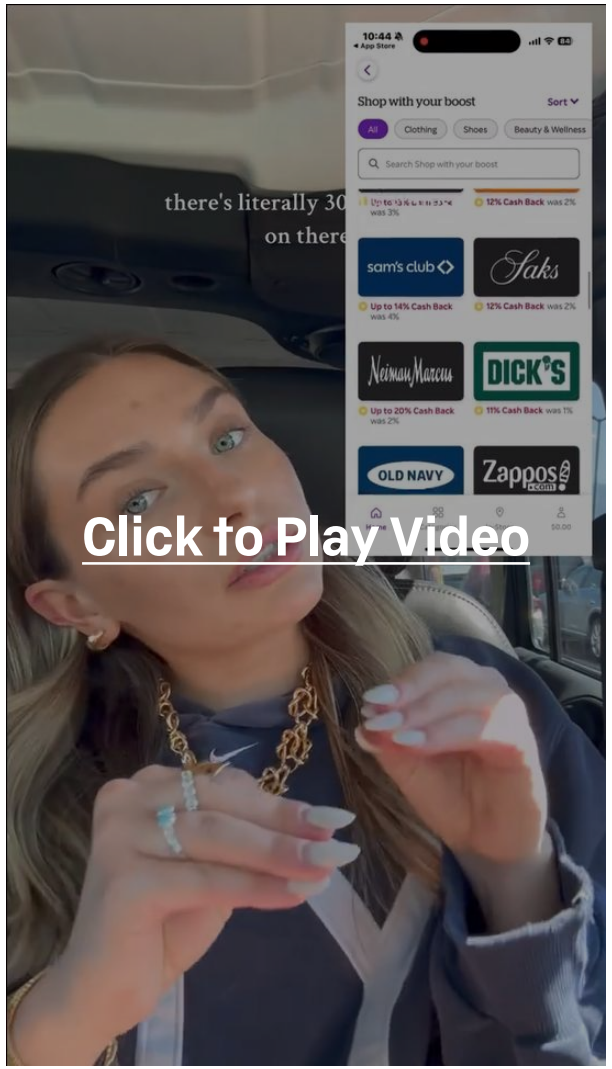
Case Study

Driving Campaign Efficiency on TikTok with Smart+ for Rakuten

M+C SAATCHI PERFORMANCE | Rakuten



About Rakuten

Rakuten is a leading shopping and rewards platform that offers Cash Back from over 3,500 partner stores across categories such as fashion, beauty, and more.

To expand its reach, Rakuten leverages TikTok with influencer-style video campaigns designed to boost awareness and drive user acquisition. However, despite ongoing creative testing and the regular rollout of fresh assets, maintaining cost efficiency on the platform had become increasingly challenging.

To address this, Rakuten explored Smart+, TikTok's AI-powered campaign solution, which optimizes performance automatically based on defined objectives.

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Objective

Driving Cost Efficiency

Rakuten's primary goal was to improve the efficiency of its TikTok campaigns by lowering cost-per metrics. In particular, the focus was on reducing Cost Per Install (CPI) and Cost Per Sign-Up (CPSU) so that results could be brought in line with the brand's performance benchmarks.

Challenge

Rising Cost Pressures

Despite continuous creative testing, costs remained stubbornly high. Fresh influencer-style video assets were introduced regularly, yet they failed to create meaningful improvements. This left Rakuten with cost-per metrics above target and highlighted the need for smarter delivery and more advanced optimization tactics.

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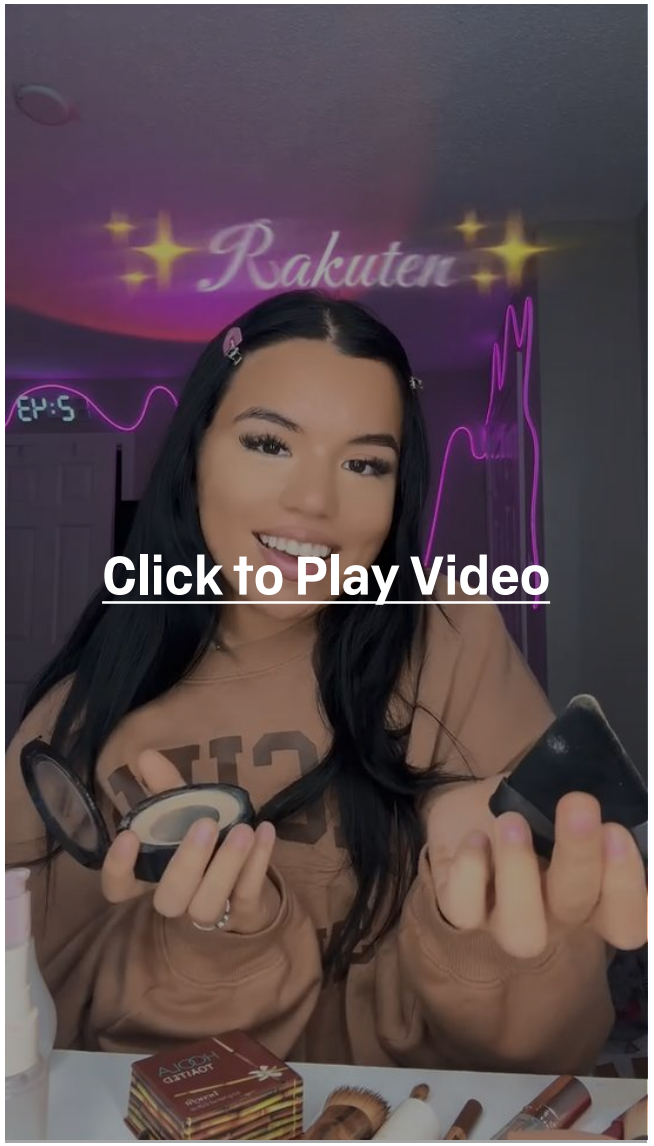
Our Approach

Rakuten's strategy combined consistency in creative with innovation in media execution. On the creative front, we continued to focus on influencer-style videos, a format that had already proven effective in resonating with TikTok audiences.

Since Smart+ campaigns require a minimum of ten videos at launch, we curated assets from two sources: previously launched Spark Ads and TikTok One videos. No major shift was made in the creative direction; instead, the emphasis was on leveraging existing content to power the campaigns.

From a media perspective, we tested two distinct Smart+ campaigns, one built entirely with Spark Ads and another solely with TikTok One videos. Each campaign was allocated a modest budget of $10K, giving the algorithm space to automatically optimize creative delivery and media placement in real time.

This allowed Smart+ to learn and adapt based on performance objectives, helping Rakuten maximize efficiency without constant manual adjustments.



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The Result

The Smart+ campaigns quickly proved to be Rakuten's most efficient and best-performing TikTok initiatives. They not only brought overall CPI and CPSU closer to target but also delivered results consistently below benchmarks in recent weeks.

In addition, Smart+ allowed Rakuten to retest and scale creatives that had previously underperformed or been paused due to fatigue, driving more value from existing assets. This became one of the best performing campaigns so far.

10%
Decrease in Cost Per Install

15%
Decrease in Cost Per Subscribed User

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Contact us

We want to talk about making your goals a reality.
Talk to us. You'll be hearing back from us soon.

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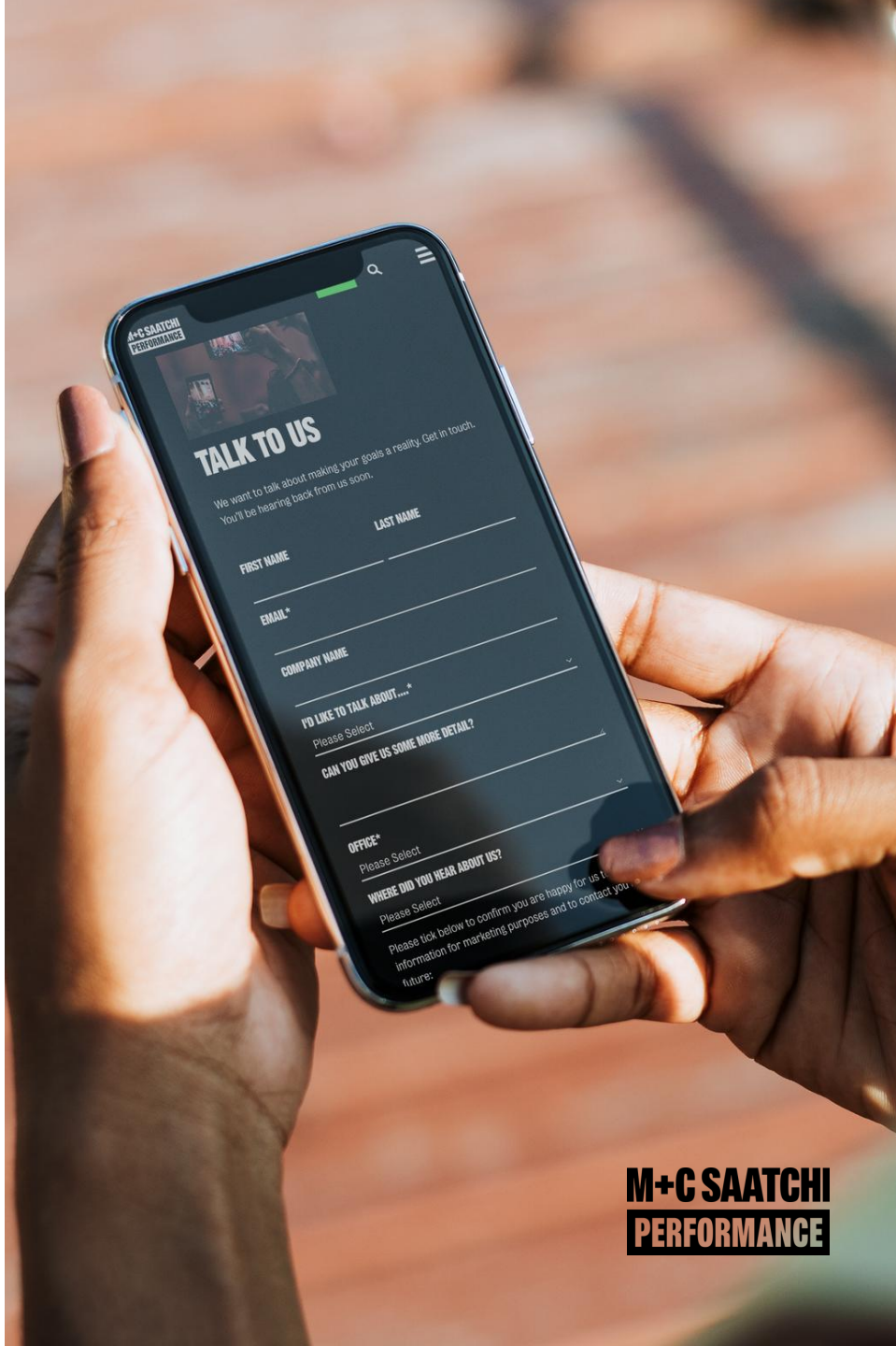

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